

century. But for the efforts of Gary Zaetz, 53, the inter-governmental agreement would not have been possible. Zaetz, the nephew of Hot as Hells substitute navigator Irwin Zaetz, pursued the case for the recovery of the remains of the doomed aircraft's crew. Around 15 years back, Gary learnt of his father's elder brother who but for a quirk of fate would not have been on the Hot as Hell: he was the navigator for another B-24, the Chugalug, whose crew survived the war.

Ever since he learnt of Kuhles's discovery while surfing through the Internet, the Vermont-based Gary campaigned to ensure that the families of the eight missing crewmen got to receive the remains of their relatives. The struggle began with petitions to his senator in Vermont who in turn contacted US Defence Secretary Robert Gates to get the bureaucratic wheels moving. Gary also wrote to senior BJP leader Jaswant Singh and Tapir Gao, BJP MP from Arunachal Pradesh East, India's eastern-most Lok Sabha constituency, where all the seven known crash sites are located. "For decades stories like these of crashed aircraft spilling crew and cargo were part of our tribal folklore. It is interesting that they will now become a bridge between two countries in the new global village," says Gao.

It took nearly a year to get the US Government to act on recovering the Hot as Hell. "We have had no problems with the Indian Government, but on the American side, we hear nothing but the possible obstacles on the proceedings," says Gary, who hopes to travel to the site of the wreckage in India.

What will make the recovery of the remains a tough task is the poor material state of the wreckage. Most aircraft have been picked clean by locals. Their aluminium, which often contains airplane markings, is sold for scrap, making it

tougher to identify the aircraft. "These expeditions should have been done 15 or 20 years ago," laments Tayeng, who is a tour operator based in Itanagar. Occasionally, a fortuitous discovery has helped identify an entire aircraft. In October last year Kuhles and Tayeng saw an unidentifiable aircraft with skeletal remains which could not be identified but an old villager showed them a silver bracelet he had picked up

THE PIONEER: Clayton Kuhles (3rd from right) with Oken Tayeng and porters in Arunachal Pradesh



Picture courtesy CLAYTON KUHLES

OPERATION RECOVERY

- India and US military to launch joint expeditions to recover bodies of US servicemen lost during World War II
- Decision taken during meeting of Indo-US Defence Policy Group in Washington between January 14 and January 18.
- US says remains of 430 servicemen from the war still in India.
- Most are crewmen of crashed bomber or transport aircraft in the North-east
- US specialists to arrive in Delhi in March. First expedition on B-24 in April-May 2008.



from the wreckage. It belonged to flight engineer Arnold Stavinoha, which helped identify the aircraft as a C-46 which had crashed in 1944 while flying between Chabua and Ondal in India. Kuhles returned the bracelet to the family of the deceased crewmen before filling out the JPAC's detailed archaeological site report form which he does with every discovery.

Finding the US MIA aircraft in India, Bangladesh, Myanmar and China was a hobby that turned into an obsession for this Arizona-based businessman in

2002. It quickly supplanted his love for mountaineering. There was no looking back after he discovered his first crashed US aircraft while trekking through north Myanmar six years ago. "North-eastern India is probably the final frontier in the global search for crashed US aircraft," says Kuhles who plans to return to the North-east this year to trek to several additional crash sites which he has been researching. "It's a thrilling experience to reach a new site," says the entrepreneur who forks out \$10,000 (Rs 4 lakh) per expedition.

The recovery of the remains of the crew is only part of a long saga to identify them. The remains will be flown to Hawaii's Hickam Air Force Base onboard a military transport aircraft and received by senior Pentagon officials with full military honours. They will then be taken to a JPAC laboratory in Hawaii where they will be identified using mitochondrial DNA tests and matched with samples taken from relatives, a process that could take several years. A delay that has the relatives worried. "At 53, I am probably the youngest, but the rest of the family is not getting any younger," says a worried Gary. His father is 84, his uncle's widow is still alive and the co-pilot's sister is 90 years. But perhaps it is the poignant thought of giving their relative a proper burial after 60 years that keeps them going. ■

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